

Sacré-Cœur

A famous Parisian landmark built as a symbol of unity after national disasters and which offers outstanding views over the city



Sacré-Cœur is one of the most popular tourist sites in Paris. Located in the heart of Montmartre, it offers commanding views of the French capital—even more so for those who climb the 237 steps to the top of the dome.

A beacon over the city

The church, which was created in the wake of France's humiliating defeat in the Franco-Prussian War (1870–1871), was seen as a symbol of atonement and hope. The project was sanctioned by Parliament in 1873, and a competition was held to decide on the design. The winner was Paul Abadie, well known as a restorer of ancient buildings. His design has been likened, rather unkindly, to a baby's bottle or a confection of whipped cream. Abadie's masterstroke, however, was to use Château-Landon stone, which hardens and whitens with age. As a result, the basilica gleams above the French capital. Sacré-Cœur was eventually consecrated in 1919. The church is dedicated to the Sacred Heart of Jesus (also commemorated by a Catholic feast day), as depicted in the huge mosaic by the French artist Luc-Olivier Merson, which adorns the apse behind the altar.



△ INTERIOR OF DOME

The dome above the chief mosaic has a clerestory and two encircling balconies. Visitors can reach this point by climbing a daunting spiral staircase.

▷ PARISIAN BASILICA

This view of Sacré-Cœur clearly shows two of its famous beehive domes. The bronze statue above the porch, depicting St. Louis holding his sword aloft, is by French sculptor Hippolyte Lefèvre.

SOMBER STRUCTURE

After the brilliant white exterior, the interior of Sacré-Cœur seems dark and still. The mix of Romanesque and Byzantine styles reflects Abadie's role on the Commission for Historical Monuments. The huge mosaic in the apse behind the altar depicts Christ in all his majesty revealing his golden heart.

